DEMOGRAPHY

INDIA'S FERTILITY PARADOX

Text by **SONALI ACHARJEE**

FEWER CHILDREN MAY HELP DEFUSE A POPULATION EXPLOSION, but that should be based on a couple's free and voluntary choice, not something thrust on them. This is the message coming from the latest United Nations Population Fund's 2025 State of World Population report, 'The Real Fertility Crisis'. It states that although India will remain the world's most populous country, its total fertility rate has fallen below the replacement level. It's not advocating panic—rather, calling attention to unmet reproductive needs, the report notes that millions are unable to achieve their desired fertility goals. The solution, it adds, lies in greater reproductive agency—the ability of individuals to make free, informed choices about sex, contraception and starting a family.

1.46 bn
India's population, making it the most populous country in the world

1.7 bn
Peak population projected in the early 2060s, before gradually declining

68%
Working-age population (15-64 years)

PROJECTED LIFE EXPECTANCY

MEN	WOMEN
71 years	74 years



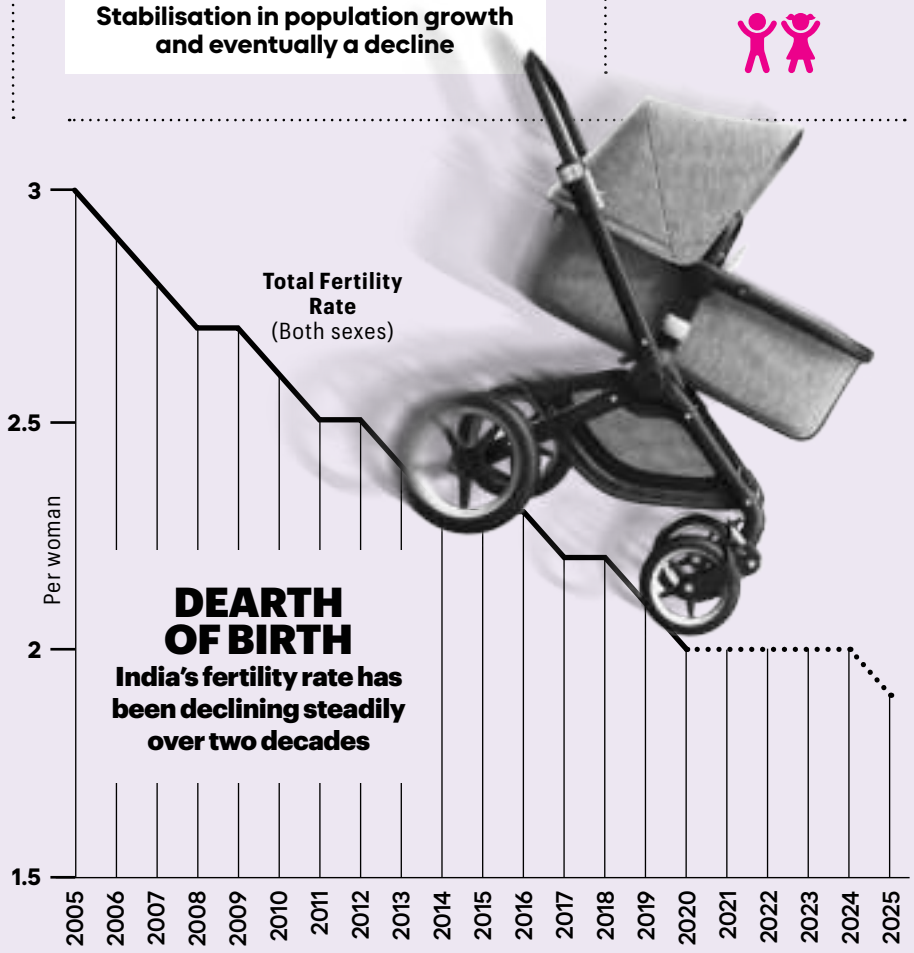
1.9
INDIA'S FERTILITY RATE*
(*A measure of the average number of children a woman is expected to have in her lifetime)

2.1
REPLACEMENT FERTILITY RATE#
(#Average number of children a woman needs to have to maintain a stable population size)

WHAT IT INDICATES
Stabilisation in population growth and eventually a decline

1960
One woman had an average of 6 kids

2025
One woman has an average of 2 kids



DEARTH OF BIRTH
India's fertility rate has been declining steadily over two decades

Source: UN, Department of Economic and Social Affairs, Population Division (2024), 'World Population Prospects: The 2024 Revision'

Illustrations by **RAJ VERMA**